Combat rule – Fleeing, surrendering and taking prisoners · SRD 5.2.1

A fight doesn't always end in death. You can **flee** (Dash, Disengage), **surrender** or **negotiate** with the **Influence** action, and **capture** a foe by **knocking it out** or **restraining** it.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Flee: **Dash** or **Disengage**.
2. Negotiate: **Influence** action, DC 15 or the monster's Int.
3. Capture: **knock out**, **grapple** or **restrain**.
4. Surrender has no SRD rule: **Table rule**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 gives the Influence action for negotiating, and the knockout rule replaces 2014's nonlethal damage.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say when a monster flees or surrenders. Fix (table rule): it flees at half HP or when alone against several foes.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe fear: trembling hands, glances at the exit, lowered weapons.

Step 1 – Decide:

The losing side may choose to flee, surrender or offer a deal.

Step 2 – Flee:

Dash to run; Disengage to avoid Opportunity Attacks.

Step 3 – Negotiate:

Influence action: the monster is willing, hesitant (check) or unwilling. DC 15 or its Intelligence if higher.

Step 4 – Capture:

Knock out (1 HP, Unconscious), grapple or restrain with manacles.

Step 5 – Aftermath:

The prisoner can be questioned, ransomed or freed. The DM decides what follows.

Example: the bandit chief is at 6 HP. The DM announces he surrenders. Léa uses Influence (Persuasion): the chief reveals the camp's location.

Choice	Means	Rule
Flee	Dash, Disengage	SRD
Negotiate	Influence action (DC 15 or Int.)	SRD
Surrender	DM's announcement	Table rule
Knock out	1 HP, Unconscious	SRD
Restrain	Manacles, rope	Table rule
Morale	Flee at half HP	Table rule

⚠ Common questions:

Which action to flee?

Dash or Disengage.

How do I negotiate?

The Influence action.

What DC?

15 or the monster's Intelligence.

Can I capture a foe?

Yes: knock out or restrain.

Can I retry after failing?

Not for 24 hours unless things change.

Does a monster always surrender?

No, the DM decides.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Monster morale

When do they flee? **Option**: at half HP.

Forced surrender

Can I force it? **Option**: no, unless Intimidation succeeds.

Prisoners

How long do they stay unconscious? **Option**: a Short Rest.

PCs fleeing

Do foes pursue? **Option**: see the Chases sheet.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Influence

Negotiating is an action with a DC.

Chases

See the Chases sheet.

Knocking out

See the Knocking a Creature Out sheet.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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